

PreACT 8/9 Printable Practice Exam 23

Reading • Exam 06

25 questions • 30 minutes

PART A - QUESTIONS

Passage 1

Reading the Ripples

Hana built her model sailboat from a plan printed on one page. Every measurement for the hull, mast, and triangular sail fit inside a neat grid. She followed each number exactly and named the finished boat Lark. For the community pond race, she expected careful construction to matter more than luck.

The evening before the race, her friend Theo watched Lark cross a washtub. “The sail pulls too far to one side,” he said. “You could tie it with a sliding knot.”

“The plan shows a fixed knot,” Hana replied. She trimmed a loose thread until it matched the drawing.

Race morning brought an uneven breeze. Flags near the boathouse hung still, while the reeds at the far curve of the pond bent and lifted. Contestants could choose any place along the starting dock, but after release they could not touch their boats.

Hana set Lark in the water near the painted center mark. During the practice run, a gust filled the sail. The boat moved quickly, then curved into a slow circle. It returned toward the dock as if it had forgotten the race.

Theo crouched beside her. “The plan didn’t know today’s wind.”

Hana wanted to blame the pond. Instead, she looked beyond Lark. Small ripples traveled from the right, but the boat’s fixed sail kept pushing its bow left. Farther down the dock, the reeds showed a steadier breeze moving almost straight toward the finish.

The rules allowed adjustments before the official start. Hana loosened the knot she had protected so carefully and retied it in a loop that could slide. She angled the sail, tested it, and changed it again. The thread no longer matched the diagram, but the sail responded to her fingers and the water in front of her.

For the official race, Hana chose a starting place near the reeds. Lark began behind two other boats. One competitor caught the first gust and hurried ahead, then drifted into a calm patch. Lark followed the narrow band of rippled water. Its sail shifted slightly at the sliding knot instead of forcing the bow into a circle.

Lark crossed the finish second. Theo cheered as if it had won. Hana lifted the dripping boat and examined the altered knot.

“Are you going to change the plan?” he asked.

Hana nodded, then drew the new loop in the margin rather than erasing the original. The printed plan still showed her how to build a boat. The pond had shown her why a boat might need to change.

R6-001

Why does Hana initially reject Theo’s suggestion to use a sliding knot?

- A) She wants to follow the printed plan exactly.
- B) The race rules forbid adjustments before the start.
- C) She believes the boat should not have a sail.
- D) Theo has never seen the finished boat.

R6-002

It can reasonably be inferred that Hana draws the new loop in the margin instead of erasing the original because she:

- A) plans to hide the change from the race officials.
- B) no longer believes the printed plan contains anything useful.
- C) sees the original plan and the pond-tested change as useful parts of what she learned.
- D) wants Theo to build an identical boat without a sail.

R6-003

In the sentence “It returned toward the dock as if it had forgotten the race,” the phrase “forgotten the race” mainly emphasizes that Lark:

- A) had been entered in the wrong event.
- B) moved in an unhelpful circle instead of continuing toward the finish.
- C) could no longer float after the first gust.
- D) was intentionally steered back by Hana.

R6-004

What is the main function of the practice run?

- A) It proves that the fastest starting boat will always win.
- B) It introduces a rule that prevents Hana from choosing a starting place.
- C) It shows Theo secretly changing the boat without permission.
- D) It reveals a problem with the fixed sail and leads Hana to observe the actual wind and water.

R6-005

How does Hana’s attitude toward the printed plan change?

- A) She moves from treating it as an exact final answer to treating it as a useful starting point that can be adapted.
- B) She first dislikes its measurements but later refuses to change any of them.
- C) She begins by trusting Theo’s changes and ends by rejecting his advice.
- D) She decides plans are useful only when a boat finishes first.

R6-006

Which choice best summarizes the passage?

- A) Theo replaces Hana’s boat after it sinks during the official race.
- B) Hana wins by copying the adjustments made by every other contestant.
- C) After a practice run exposes a flaw, Hana adapts her carefully built boat to the day’s conditions and expands what the plan has taught her.
- D) Race officials require Hana to erase the original boat plan before competing.

Passage 2

Passage A: Shape the Story for Listeners

Our town archive records long interviews with residents. A single conversation may last three hours and wander from a factory strike to a favorite sandwich. Full recordings matter, but most visitors do not have an afternoon to explore each one. Carefully edited audio can provide an inviting entrance.

For an exhibit about the riverfront, I assembled five-minute tracks around clear themes. I removed repeated phrases, unrelated interruptions, and stretches in which the interviewer adjusted equipment. I did not rearrange answers to change their meaning. Each track identifies where cuts occur, and the complete recording and transcript remain available in the archive.

Editing is a form of guidance, so it requires responsibility. Listeners should know whose choices shaped a track and how to find the source. When those conditions are met, a concise version can help

a voice reach people who might never discover it inside hours of audio.

Passage B: Keep the Room in the Recording

An oral history contains more than sentences. A long pause before an answer may show uncertainty. A speaker may correct a confident first memory after hearing a clock or another person in the room. Background sounds can locate the conversation in a workshop, kitchen, or busy street.

Removing such moments may make a recording smoother while making its creation harder to understand. Listeners need opportunities to hear hesitation, revision, and the interviewer's influence. These features remind us that memory is produced in a conversation, not delivered as a perfect speech.

Short excerpts can help people find relevant material, but they should point toward an unaltered recording. Editors can provide timestamps, notes, and transcripts instead of silently polishing every rough edge. The aim is not to make long interviews difficult to use. It is to preserve enough of the room around the words for future listeners to evaluate how the story was told.

R6-007

Which choice best states the central idea of Passage A?

- A) Archives should delete full interviews after producing short exhibits.
- B) Transparent, responsible editing can make long oral histories more approachable while preserving access to the source.
- C) Every unrelated interruption belongs in a five-minute exhibit track.
- D) Visitors understand interviews only when no transcript is provided.

R6-008

Why does Passage A describe an interview wandering from a factory strike to a favorite sandwich?

- A) To prove that neither topic belongs in a town archive.
- B) To argue that interviewers should limit every answer to one sentence.
- C) To show that residents should be interviewed only about food.
- D) To illustrate how a long recording may contain varied material that can be difficult for visitors to navigate.

R6-009

According to Passage B, why can pauses and background sounds be important?

- A) They can reveal uncertainty, revision, setting, and the conditions in which a memory was told.
- B) They guarantee that every remembered detail is factually correct.
- C) They make timestamps and transcripts unnecessary.
- D) They prevent interviewers from influencing conversations.

R6-010

As used in Passage B, "polishing" most nearly means:

- A) cleaning the recording equipment.
- B) making the speaker's voice louder.
- C) smoothing away rough or complicated features through editing.
- D) transferring an interview onto a physical disc.

R6-011

The passages differ mainly in that Passage A emphasizes:

- A) why interviews should avoid personal memories, while Passage B favors them.
- B) the usefulness of concise edited entry points, while Passage B emphasizes the evidence contained in unaltered context.
- C) video recordings, while Passage B discusses only printed biographies.

D) the cost of archive equipment, while Passage B focuses on building size.

R6-012

Which statement would both authors most likely support?

- A) Short excerpts should replace complete recordings permanently.
- B) Editors should remove all signs that an interview was a conversation.
- C) Only visitors willing to hear three-hour recordings should use an archive.
- D) Edited excerpts can be useful if choices are transparent and listeners can reach the complete source.

Passage 3

Who Faces Whom?

Classroom discussions are often held in rows facing a teacher, even when students are expected to respond to one another. Social researcher Mina Solis wondered whether the arrangement of seats influences who speaks and how participants connect ideas.

Her team recruited thirty after-school groups of eight students each. Every group discussed the same question for twenty minutes: How should an unused room at school be redesigned? Half the groups sat in three short rows facing an adult facilitator. The others sat in a circle with the facilitator as one member of the ring. Groups were randomly assigned, and facilitators used the same opening instructions and did not call on individual students.

Observers counted how many students spoke, the total speaking time of each participant, and how often a speaker referred to another student's idea. Three reviewers who did not know the seating arrangement later rated each group's final proposal for usefulness and detail.

In row groups, an average of 5.3 students spoke. In circle groups, the average was 7.1. Speaking time was also distributed more evenly in circles. Circle participants referred to classmates' earlier comments nearly twice as often as row participants did. The final proposals from the two arrangements received similar ratings for usefulness and detail.

The recordings suggested that physical attention differed. Students in rows looked mainly toward the facilitator, even when a classmate was speaking from the side or behind them. Circle participants could see one another without turning far. In interviews, several said it felt natural to answer a classmate directly. One student noted, "There wasn't one front where the important answer had to go."

The study does not show that circles improve every discussion. The groups met only once, and the task involved generating a proposal rather than learning a set of facts. A circle may also be impractical in a crowded room. Although facilitators followed a script, they could see the seating arrangement and might have reacted to it in subtle ways.

Solis concluded that furniture does not determine what people will say, but it can make certain interactions easier. Changing the direction participants face may change whether a discussion feels like many replies to one leader or a conversation shared across a group.

R6-013

Which choice best states the main idea of the passage?

- A) A circular seating arrangement may broaden participation and encourage students to respond to one another, though it does not guarantee a better final proposal.
- B) Rows always produce more detailed proposals than circles do.
- C) Facilitators should call on every student in a fixed order.
- D) Seat arrangement determines exactly what each participant will say.

R6-014

Which result did the researchers observe?

- A) Every student spoke in every circle group.
- B) Row groups referred to classmates' ideas twice as often as circle groups.
- C) Circle groups averaged more student speakers than row groups.
- D) Reviewers rated all circle proposals higher in usefulness and detail.

R6-015

What is the main purpose of the student's comment about there being no single "front"?

- A) To explain why students could not locate the classroom door.
- B) To illustrate how the circle may have reduced the sense that all responses should be directed toward one authority.
- C) To prove that facilitators left the circle before discussion began.
- D) To show that students in rows were unable to hear one another.

R6-016

Why did facilitators use the same opening instructions and avoid calling on individuals?

- A) To make every group select an identical room design.
- B) To prevent observers from counting speaking time.
- C) To ensure facilitators could not see the arrangement of seats.
- D) To reduce differences in facilitator behavior as an explanation for participation patterns.

R6-017

Which combination of findings most strongly supports the claim that circles changed interaction among students, not merely the number who spoke?

- A) Speaking time was more evenly shared, and participants referred to classmates' earlier comments nearly twice as often.
- B) Each group had eight students, and every discussion lasted twenty minutes.
- C) The task concerned an unused room, and reviewers rated final proposals.
- D) Facilitators could see the seating arrangement, and groups met once.

R6-018

Which choice best describes the passage's overall structure?

- A) It gives instructions for buying furniture and then compares prices.
- B) It presents one student's opinion as the only evidence about discussion quality.
- C) It introduces a question, describes a controlled seating comparison, reports behavioral and rating results, and then discusses limits and implications.
- D) It argues that proposal quality can never be measured and removes the reviewer data.

Passage 4

Turning Away the Rain

On a mountain meadow, the flowers of one small plant hang downward from flexible stems. Their bell-shaped petals form a roof above the pollen-bearing parts. Botanist Lila Adebayo wondered whether this downward angle protects pollen during rain.

Adebayo's team selected sixty newly opened flowers of similar size. Twenty remained in their natural downward position. Twenty were gently supported with thin wire so their openings faced upward. The final twenty received loose wire loops that did not change their angle. This third group allowed the researchers to check whether contact with wire, rather than flower position, affected the results.

Before the test, the team counted pollen grains on selected structures inside each flower. A sprinkler then produced the same light rain over all sixty flowers for three minutes. Covered containers beneath the plants collected runoff, and the researchers counted the pollen remaining afterward.

Naturally downward flowers retained an average of 84 percent of their pollen. Flowers with loose wire loops retained 82 percent, a very similar amount. Upward-facing flowers retained only 51 percent. Cameras showed that the downward petals shed most drops along their outer surfaces. In the upward flowers, water pooled inside the bells and carried pollen over their edges.

The team next tested whether wet pollen that remained inside the flowers could still function. Samples from upward-facing flowers produced fewer growing pollen tubes in a laboratory dish than samples from the downward flowers. This suggested that rain could reduce pollen performance as well as wash grains away.

After the rain test, the supports were removed. The researchers observed the plants for two weeks but did not find a clear difference in fruit production among the groups. Insects may have delivered additional dry pollen after the experiment, partly replacing what the simulated rain removed.

Adebayo cautioned that a sprinkler cannot reproduce every mountain storm. Wind can drive drops sideways, and heavier rain may bend stems or damage petals. Flower angle may also affect temperature and access for pollinating insects. Still, the similar results for natural flowers and loose-loop controls strengthen the evidence that orientation itself helped shield pollen during the brief rain test.

R6-019

Which choice best states the central idea of the passage?

- A) Upward-facing flowers retain more pollen because they collect water inside their petals.
- B) A downward flower angle can reduce pollen loss and damage during brief rain, though later fruit production depends on additional factors.
- C) Wire loops prevent flowers from producing pollen under all conditions.
- D) Mountain rain affects petals but cannot influence pollen performance.

R6-020

Why did some downward flowers receive loose wire loops?

- A) To make their openings face upward during rain.
- B) To increase the amount of pollen each flower produced.
- C) To keep insects away for the entire two-week study.
- D) To test whether contact with wire, rather than a change in orientation, affected the results.

R6-021

As used in the passage, “shed” most nearly means:

- A) allowed to run off.
- B) absorbed and stored.
- C) changed into pollen.
- D) measured inside a container.

R6-022

Which step occurred before the researchers tested pollen samples in laboratory dishes?

- A) They measured fruit production for two full years.
- B) They exposed the flower groups to the same simulated rain and counted remaining pollen.
- C) They identified every insect that visited the meadow.
- D) They reproduced several kinds of wind-driven mountain storms.

R6-023

What can reasonably be inferred from the lack of a clear fruit-production difference after two weeks?

- A) The initial rain test did not remove any pollen from upward flowers.
- B) Downward orientation makes pollinating insects unnecessary.
- C) Later pollen delivery may compensate for some short-term pollen loss.

D) The wire supports permanently prevented every flower from producing fruit.

R6-024

What is the main function of the final paragraph?

- A) To claim that a sprinkler reproduces every feature of a mountain storm.
- B) To argue that flower angle has no possible effect other than rain protection.
- C) To introduce results showing that heavy wind increases pollen retention.
- D) To identify limits and other possible effects while explaining why the control group strengthens the orientation finding.

R6-025

Which choice best summarizes the experiment's findings?

- A) Upward-facing flowers retained the most pollen and produced the strongest pollen tubes.
- B) Downward flowers shed rain, retained more functional pollen, and performed like loose-loop controls, although later fruit differences were unclear.
- C) Wire contact caused all observed differences between downward and upward flowers.
- D) The test established that flower angle determines fruit production in every mountain storm.

PART B - ANSWER KEY + EXPLANATIONS

R6-001 - Correct: A) She wants to follow the printed plan exactly.

Explanation: Hana points out that the plan shows a fixed knot and even trims the loose thread to match the drawing.

R6-002 - Correct: C) sees the original plan and the pond-tested change as useful parts of what she learned.

Explanation: The final lines state that the plan taught her how to build the boat, while the pond showed why it needed to change. Keeping both records reflects that combined understanding.

R6-003 - Correct: B) moved in an unhelpful circle instead of continuing toward the finish.

Explanation: The fixed sail makes the boat curve into a slow circle and return toward the dock, moving away from the race's intended direction.

R6-004 - Correct: D) It reveals a problem with the fixed sail and leads Hana to observe the actual wind and water.

Explanation: Lark's circular path exposes the weakness in the fixed setup. Hana then studies the ripples and reeds before revising the knot and sail angle.

R6-005 - Correct: A) She moves from treating it as an exact final answer to treating it as a useful starting point that can be adapted.

Explanation: At first Hana protects every detail of the diagram. By the end, she preserves the plan but adds the sliding loop learned through testing on the pond.

R6-006 - Correct: C) After a practice run exposes a flaw, Hana adapts her carefully built boat to the day's conditions and expands what the plan has taught her.

Explanation: Hana changes the fixed knot after observing wind and water, races successfully, and records the modification alongside the original instructions.

R6-007 - Correct: B) Transparent, responsible editing can make long oral histories more approachable while preserving access to the source.

Explanation: Passage A supports concise thematic tracks when cuts are identified and complete recordings and transcripts remain available.

R6-008 - Correct: D) To illustrate how a long recording may contain varied material that can be difficult for visitors to navigate.

Explanation: The contrast illustrates the range and wandering structure of a multi-hour conversation, supporting the case for short thematic entry points.

R6-009 - Correct: A) They can reveal uncertainty, revision, setting, and the conditions in which a memory was told.

Explanation: Passage B explains that pauses may show uncertainty, sounds can locate the interview, and surrounding events may lead a speaker to revise a memory.

R6-010 - Correct: C) smoothing away rough or complicated features through editing.

Explanation: The author warns against silently removing pauses, corrections, and background details merely to make a recording smoother.

R6-011 - Correct: B) the usefulness of concise edited entry points, while Passage B emphasizes the evidence contained in unaltered context.

Explanation: Passage A focuses on helping visitors enter long collections through edited tracks. Passage B stresses that pauses, revisions, and room sounds help listeners evaluate the telling.

R6-012 - Correct: D) Edited excerpts can be useful if choices are transparent and listeners can reach the complete source.

Explanation: Passage A labels cuts and preserves the full recording; Passage B allows short excerpts when they point toward an unaltered recording with supporting information.

R6-013 - Correct: A) A circular seating arrangement may broaden participation and encourage students to respond to one another, though it does not guarantee a better final proposal.

Explanation: Circle groups included more speakers, shared time more evenly, and referred to peers more often, while proposal ratings were similar across arrangements.

R6-014 - Correct: C) Circle groups averaged more student speakers than row groups.

Explanation: Circle groups averaged 7.1 speakers compared with 5.3 in row groups; the passage does not claim that every student spoke in every circle.

R6-015 - Correct: B) To illustrate how the circle may have reduced the sense that all responses should be directed toward one authority.

Explanation: The comment supports the observation that circle participants could address classmates directly instead of orienting all important answers toward the facilitator.

R6-016 - Correct: D) To reduce differences in facilitator behavior as an explanation for participation patterns.

Explanation: Standard instructions and no individual calling help keep the facilitation approach consistent while seating arrangement varies.

R6-017 - Correct: A) Speaking time was more evenly shared, and participants referred to classmates' earlier comments nearly twice as often.

Explanation: More even speaking time shows broader distribution, while increased references to peers directly indicate stronger connection among participants' ideas.

R6-018 - Correct: C) It introduces a question, describes a controlled seating comparison, reports behavioral and rating results, and then discusses limits and implications.

Explanation: The passage proceeds from the research question through methods and results to cautions and Solis's broader conclusion about interaction.

R6-019 - Correct: B) A downward flower angle can reduce pollen loss and damage during brief rain, though later fruit production depends on additional factors.

Explanation: Downward and loose-loop flowers retained much more pollen, and their pollen performed better, but later pollination may have erased differences in fruit production.

R6-020 - Correct: D) To test whether contact with wire, rather than a change in orientation, affected the results.

Explanation: The loose loops touched the flowers without changing their angle, providing a control for the possible effect of the support material itself.

R6-021 - Correct: A) allowed to run off.

Explanation: Cameras showed drops traveling along the outer petal surfaces instead of pooling inside, so the petals shed water by allowing it to run off.

R6-022 - Correct: B) They exposed the flower groups to the same simulated rain and counted remaining pollen.

Explanation: The sprinkler test and pollen-retention counts came first; the team next examined whether the wet pollen that remained could function.

R6-023 - Correct: C) Later pollen delivery may compensate for some short-term pollen loss.

Explanation: The passage suggests that insects delivered additional dry pollen after the test, partly replacing what the simulated rain had removed.

R6-024 - Correct: D) To identify limits and other possible effects while explaining why the control group strengthens the orientation finding.

Explanation: The paragraph notes differences between simulated and natural storms and other roles of angle, then points to the similarity between natural and loose-loop flowers as supporting evidence.

R6-025 - Correct: B) Downward flowers shed rain, retained more functional pollen, and performed like loose-loop controls, although later fruit differences were unclear.

Explanation: Downward and loose-loop flowers retained about 82–84 percent of pollen and had better pollen performance than upward flowers, but fruit production later showed no clear group difference.